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Sovereign States and Moral Stakes:

Interpreting Hobbes and Locke on International Relations

The theories of Thomas Hobbes and John Locke, two pivotal figures in the development of political philosophy, have significantly shaped the conceptual framework of modern governance and social structures. Their theories on the state of nature and a social contract lay the foundation for understanding states' behavior, nationally and internationally. While Hobbes explicitly describes the international system as a state of nature which is characterized by perpetual conflict without supreme authority, Locke does not directly discuss international relations. This absence offers an opportunity for the application of Locke's less pessimistic views of human nature and governance to the international arena. Hobbes' and Locke's perspectives on the state of nature and state of war provide crucial insights into international relations, particularly in understanding the rights and obligations of state behavior as applied to sovereignty, international institutions, and enforcement.

The state of nature, meaning the condition of human beings before the implementation of political structures, is the fundamental basis for Hobbes and Locke's distinct political theories. Hobbes famously describes this primal state as one where life is "solitary, poor, ugly, brutish, and short,"¹ illustrating a condition dominated by fear and the relentless pursuit of survival. For Hobbes, the institution of government is necessary because it protects a state's population from

¹ Hobbes, Thomas. *Leviathan, or, the Matter, Forme, and Power of a Common-Wealth, Ecclesiasticall and Civill*. Andrew Crooke, at the Green Dragon, 1651, page 78. (See: *Leviathan*).

the competing agendas of its people. Hobbes argues that governmental structure requires individuals to relinquish their rights to freedom and individual authority to the sovereign in order to maintain the security of the collective.² On the other hand, Locke views the state of nature as a condition of relative peace and equality, governed by natural law, where individuals are free, yet bound by a moral obligation to respect each other's life, liberty, and possessions.³ Their distinct views on the state of nature is not merely a theoretical construct but a lens through which the essential tenets of political order and avoidance of disorder can be understood.

While Hobbes and Locke are often positioned at opposite ends of the spectrum concerning their views on the state of nature, a closer examination reveals underlying similarities that are particularly significant in the context of international relations. Both philosophers fundamentally grapple with the challenge of how independent states can coexist in a system lacking a central authority, a question that remains central to modern international politics. Political scientist Alexander Wendt aptly distinguishes their views on other sovereign countries in foreign affairs: "in Hobbesian cultures, it is 'enemy,' in Lockean 'rival.'"⁴ The two philosophers are part of the same continuum, differing mainly in intensity and approach rather than fundamental principles.

Hobbes' argument for the necessity of government lies in his definition of the state of nature, which extends to the international political system. He argues that the state of nature is a perpetual state of war. For Hobbes, the state of war is not just the act of fighting, but also the possible threat of war. He compares the nature of war to the nature of weather, writing that the makeup of foul weather is not "in a shower or two of rain; but in an inclination thereto of many

² Id.

³ Locke, John. *Two Treatises of Government*. The Works of John Locke, 1823, page 163. (See: Second Treatise).

⁴ Wendt A. *Social Theory of International Politics*. Cambridge University Press; 1999, page 258. (See: Wendt).

days together.”⁵ In this metaphor, Hobbes highlights that the essence of warlike conditions lies not solely in overt battles, but in the ongoing atmosphere of tension and readiness for conflict. The threat of war, like looming clouds of an incipient thunderstorm, is an indication of wartime. A constant state of alert, where sovereigns stand “in continuall jealousies, and in the state and posture of Gladiators; having their weapons pointing, and their eyes fixed on one another,” allows them to be prepared for conflict, not out of sheer hostility but as a necessary stance to safeguard their independence and maintain the industry of their subjects.⁶ Hobbes suggests that while non-stop preparation for war might seem to imply a miserable existence, it instead supports the flourishing of a state’s economy and the security of its people, thus justifying the state of war as a protective and even productive condition.

Separate from the state of nature, Locke identifies the state of war as a condition specifically characterized by the absence of a common superior with the authority to resolve disputes and the presence of actual or threatened force. He clarifies “the plain difference between the state of Nature and the state of war, which however some men have confounded, are as far distant as a state of peace, goodwill, mutual assistance, and preservation; and a state of enmity, malice, violence and mutual destruction are one from another.”⁷ In his view, the transition to a state of war occurs when there is a declared design of force upon another, emphasizing that the state of war is an active and temporary condition of conflict, not a perpetual threat. Locke’s differentiation allows a potential for peace and cooperation, contingent on the establishment and recognition of a society consenting to a common authority that can adjudicate disputes and enforce the law globally.

⁵ Leviathan, page 77.

⁶ Leviathan, page 79.

⁷ Second Treatise, page 113.

While Locke posits a higher threshold for transitioning to a state of war, it is imperative to recognize that both define the state of nature as a condition of insecurity. Locke's rhetorical question reveals the crux of his argument as follows: "If man in the state of Nature be so free as has been said, if he be absolute lord of his own person and possessions, equal to the greatest and subject to nobody, why will he part with his freedom, this empire, and subject himself to the dominion and control of any other power?"⁸ He acknowledges that despite the theoretical freedom of the state of nature, the reality is fraught with "fears and continual dangers," making the environment "very unsafe, very insecure" such that society must consent to governance.⁹ This acknowledgment aligns with Hobbes, who also emphasizes the precariousness of a lawless state where "every man is a king, and every man his equal," because without consent to governance, the lack of justice is threatening.¹⁰ They similarly arrive at a need for governance as a refuge from the inherent risks and chaos of the pre-political state. Locke sees the transition as driven by rational self-interest to protect property and ensure security, while Hobbes views it as assurance from relentless danger. Each provides a framework that, while distinct, converges on the necessity of establishing a governed society to mitigate the vulnerability of the state of nature.

Nevertheless, one significant point of divergence between Hobbes and Locke lies in their conceptions of sovereignty. Hobbes contends that in entering society, individuals must surrender their natural rights to a sovereign, who wields absolute power to ensure security and order. Only with a sovereign state can society be protected from the looming threat of war and still have time for industry, arts and culture, knowledge, and society.¹¹ Without the sovereign authority, its

⁸ Second Treatise, page 159.

⁹ Id.

¹⁰ Id.

¹¹ Leviathan, page 78.

people would be in “continual fear, and danger of violent death...”¹² Hobbes advocates for strong, undivided sovereignty as the cornerstone for peace and security. In his view, the absolute power of a sovereign authority, namely the Leviathan, is essential to prevent the perpetual conflict of the state of nature. A formidable central authority is necessary to maintain order and prevent the return to a warlike state.

On the other hand, Locke’s theories question sovereign authority, centering around sovereignty as a right, not a given. As Wendt notes, Locke’s framework suggests that “underlying rivalry is a right to sovereignty,” which becomes a recognized right only when other states acknowledge it.¹³ Locke’s principles do not merely attribute sovereignty to individual states; rather, these principles elevate it to the status of an institution shared among states. In a Lockean world, the institution of sovereignty modifies the “balance of threat,” where dangers are viewed not as existential but manageable, allowing for greater trust and easier formation of alliances.¹⁴ Locke’s theory, when applied to the international stage, might advocate for a system where the balance of power is more evenly distributed. Then, diplomatic negotiations and international law would play an enhanced role in maintaining global peace and order. If sovereigns do not concede any of their powers, the global scene could resemble a Lockean landscape rather than a Hobbesian one, emphasizing mutual recognition and respect for sovereignty, rather than overwhelming military dominance.

Further applying the idea of sovereignty to international institutions, the concept of a global sovereign, an international authority that effectively governs states, presents different challenges and opportunities according to Hobbes and Locke. For Hobbes, the establishment of a global sovereign is implausible; his theory suggests that for there to be total control internally

¹² Id.

¹³ Wendt, page 280.

¹⁴ Wendt, page 282.

within states, an existential threat is necessary to justify such coercive power.¹⁵ Hobbes views the external threat as a fundamental justification for a sovereign's power to make and enforce laws. Therefore, a global state acting as an international superior power could potentially lead to internal strife rather than global order, as it would undermine the foundational threat that legitimizes sovereign power. Notably, international bodies like the United Nations (UN), which lack any true enforcement mechanism, could align with Hobbesian theory if they do not override the sovereign authority of individual states.

Locke might also view international institutions with caution, as his philosophy advocates for minimal control over individuals and prioritizes the preservation of natural rights. However, he also recognizes the potential benefits of such a global authority in terms of accountability and dispute resolution. Locke argues, "To avoid the state of war... where there is no authority to decide between the contender[s] is one great reason of men's putting themselves into society..."¹⁶ Locke emphasizes the importance of all societal structures that provide mechanisms for resolving disputes and achieving relief through "appeal."¹⁷ He implies that the state of nature includes inherent judicial capabilities among individuals. However, individuals may lack the impartiality to judge their own cases fairly, tending to punish offenders too harshly or be lenient towards themselves. To Locke, this limitation does not necessarily precipitate a state of war but underscores the need for established laws and communal governance. Thus, while Hobbes sees a global sovereign as a destabilizing force due to the lack of an existential threat to justify its

¹⁵ Leviathan, page 110.

Note: Here, I am referencing Hobbes' beliefs on what sovereigns may do within their total control. The state of nature as a constant threat of war, to Hobbes, is the necessary justification to enable the institution of a sovereign with coercive powers. These ideas are reinforced in the Leviathan, Chapter 17, where Hobbes emphasizes the need of government to escape the state of nature that he likens to a state of war. Moreover, in Chapter 18, Hobbes clarifies the rights of the sovereign as an absolute authority, including the use of coercive power to maintain security and order.

¹⁶ Second Treatise, page 114.

¹⁷ Second Treatise, page 113.

power, Locke views it as a potential extension of societal judicial structures that could maintain peace and resolve conflicts between civil societies.

Moreover, Locke's advocacy for judicial authority to prevent a descent into chaos suggests that he would likely support the role of international institutions in arbitration. He asserts: "Want of a common judge with authority, puts all men in a state of nature: force without right, upon a man's person, makes a state of war, both where there is, and is not, a common judge."¹⁸ Applying this concept to international relations, Locke may likely support the idea of international bodies like the UN's International Court of Justice, and European Union (EU) that uphold laws and mediate disputes, as they fulfill the essential role of a common judge. Member states cede certain sovereign powers to achieve greater collective security and economic stability, which he might view as a rational extension of social contract principles to the international arena. Locke could theoretically argue that in the absence of a global sovereign, international systems prevent the cosmopolitan system from devolving into the chaos and conflict Hobbes feared would be dominated by continual war.

Locke also differs from Hobbes in that his less pessimistic concept of the state of nature points to the existence of an international civil society, which operates under natural laws. He explains, "There is another power in every commonwealth which one may call natural, because it is that which answers to the power every man naturally had before he entered into society... So that under this consideration the whole community is one body in the state of Nature in respect of all other states or persons out of its community."¹⁹ Locke depicts a federative power of states, managing war, peace, leagues, alliances, and all transactions with those outside the commonwealth, effectively functioning in a state of nature with respect to other countries.²⁰ His

¹⁸ Second Treatise, page 113.

¹⁹ Second Treatise, page 168.

²⁰ Id.

framework not only emphasizes the potential for peace and cooperation in international relations, but also acknowledges the inherent powers that sovereign states retain in managing their external affairs, reflecting a complex layer of interaction that transcends the anarchic outlook proposed by Hobbes.

While Locke may envision a more cooperative global order rooted in mutual respect and natural law, he too would see the necessity for mechanisms such as international courts or treaties that ensure these principles are upheld and violations addressed. The convergence of Hobbes' and Locke's thoughts on the necessity of enforcement mechanisms highlights a fundamental shared aspect of governance theory: the recognition that laws, to be effective, require a means of enforcement that is respected and adhered to by all parties. As Hobbes explains, "Where there is no common Power, there is no Law: where there is no Law, no Injustice."²¹ He further emphasizes the critical role of enforcement in ensuring the viability of agreements: "And Covenants, without the Sword, are but Words, and of no strength to secure a man at all."²² Hobbes' perspective portrays a world where the absence of a coercive power inevitably leads to disorder and injustice, emphasizing that for law and agreement to be effective, society must consent to a capable authority that can enforce compliance and deter violations.

Similarly, Locke believes all leaders of independent states, much like individuals in the state of nature, possess the executive power to enforce the law of nature. Each individual and state by extension, has the right and responsibility to uphold and execute natural laws. Locke further elaborates that the power of execution is "put into every man's hands, whereby everyone has a right to punish..."²³ In the state of nature, justice is maintained not through a centralized authority, but through the collective responsibility of all individuals. His perspective suggests

²¹ Leviathan, page 79.

²² Leviathan, page 103.

²³ Second Treatise, page 108.

that world leaders, much like individuals in the state of nature, have the duty to enforce international laws and norms.

While Locke's theories offer a compelling framework for governance based on mutual respect and natural law, there are reasons to be cautious about fully applying his principles to international relations, especially given his views on property rights. Locke asserts that individuals have a natural right to property derived from labor, but his conclusions can lead to expansionist tendencies if states invoke similar principles to justify territorial expansion or resource extraction. He states, "As much land as a man tills, plants, improves, cultivates, and can use the product of, so much is his property."²⁴ His perspective, when extended to an international level, could theoretically support the notion that states are justified in claiming unoccupied or underutilized lands, potentially leading to conflicts over land and resources. Expansionist interpretations of Locke's property rights could inadvertently encourage a form of neo-colonialism or justify aggressive foreign policy under the guise of economic necessity and development.²⁵

However, Locke's concept of property rights also includes significant protections against government overreach, providing a basis for individuals to enforce these rights against their own governments. This aspect of Locke's theory suggests that property rights could serve as a foundation for taking grievances against a state to an international court because these rights transcend the sovereign's sphere of absolute control. In contrast, Hobbes would view such actions as a form of rebellion. Locke's approach, therefore, not only offers a framework for understanding individual states' rights but also hints at how these rights might be defended on an

²⁴ Second Treatise, page 118.

²⁵ Williams, H. (1996). John Locke and International Politics. In: International Relations and the Limits of Political Theory. Palgrave Macmillan, London. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-1-349-24940-4_7

international stage, potentially providing a check on sovereign powers and influencing international law.

Incorporating Locke's emphasis on justice, fairness, and natural rights into global cooperation is vital to understanding the foundational theories of international relations. While Hobbes' perspective offers valuable insights into the concern of a threatening state of nature, it is Locke's framework that provides the balance needed in modern global practices, urging society to see beyond mere survival and constant conflict. Locke's theories advocate for an international arena where states act not as enemies in perpetual conflict, as Hobbes might suggest, but as rivals within a grand social contract. This shift from Hobbes' view of states as enemies to Locke's view of them as rivals illustrates the nuanced continuum between these philosophers. Embracing Locke's principles, alongside the cautionary notes of Hobbes, ensures that both security and human dignity are preserved in the global arena.